

JESSICA ROOD

Department of Economics, Rice University, Houston TX

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EDUCATION

PhD in Economics; fourth year.

Expected 2028

Rice University, Houston, TX

- *Graduate First Year Fellowship*, 2022

Bachelor of Science in Economics

May 2022

Minors in Mathematics and Political Science & International Relations.

Cumulative GPA 4.0

Truman State University, Kirksville, MO.

- *Outstanding Student in Economics*, 2022

RESEARCH AND TEACHING INTERESTS

Primary: Labor Economics, Experimental Economics

Secondary: Family Economics

WORKS IN PROGRESS

- [“Beliefs, Attention, and Investments in Early Childhood”](#) with Flávio Cunha, Snejana Nihtianova, and Anja-Lize van der Merwe [NBER WP #35150]
- [“Turnover as a Barrier in Early Childcare Supports,”](#) with Ji-Hee Lee

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

W.E. Upjohn Institute, Kalamazoo, MI

Summer 2026

AEA Summer Dissertation Fellowship

Texas Policy Lab/Kinder Institute for Urban Research, Houston, TX

Summer 2023-Present

Graduate Research Assistant

Project Management: Baby Sign Language Pilot Program

- Co-designing a randomized controlled trial to evaluate an existing 8-week baby sign language program’s effects on caregiver-child bonding and child development outcomes;
- Engaging community partners to establish recruitment pipelines and program deployment;
- Building grant proposals to secure project funding

Experimental Research: LENA Start Program (RCT)

- Cleaned and merged device-recording and survey data from a 10-week Randomized Controlled Trial in Alief ISD administered over 5 years;
- Assessed sensitivity of OLS estimates to attrition and recording choice using balancing, IPW, and Lee Bounds;
- Implemented causal forests to estimate heterogeneous treatment effects

Policy Analysis: State Early Childcare Programs

- Contributed to qualitative data collection across three Texas state-run childcare support initiatives, conducting interviews and organizing program documentation;
- Co-developed codebooks and coded 90+ interviews alongside a four-person research team;

- Produced stakeholder-facing reports synthesizing program features and key findings, supported with direct quotes from interviews

American Institute for Economic Research, Great Barrington, MA

Summer 2021

Summer Research Intern

- Assisted in development of a book chapter detailing a qualitative comparison of two counties, which highlighted the regulation relevant to micro-wind power;
- Collected data and generated figures for various research projects

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Rice University, Economics Department, Houston, TX,

Fall 2025-Spring 2026

Teaching Assistant, Applied Econometrics

- Led recitations designed to support course content (introduction to RStudio and theoretical concepts);
- Graded problem sets, projects, and exams;
- Maintained flexible office hours to accommodate student schedules

Truman State University Economics Department, Kirksville, MO

Spring 2020/2021

Teaching Assistant, Self & Society

- Developed and implemented interdisciplinary curriculum with Dr. Gillette;
- Spearheaded and oversaw classroom discussion and activities;
- Aided in the collection and assessment of assignments

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Good Reason Houston, Houston TX,

October 2025 – January 2026

Research Consultant

- Analyzed data from a 900+ respondent caregiver survey on familiarity with and attitudes toward public pre-K in Houston, TX;
- Translated quantitative findings into focus-group design and a mixed-methods report for district stakeholders and the public

PRESENTATIONS & MENTORSHIP

- *Student Presenter*, “Beliefs, Conversations, and Language Development in Early Childhood: Evidence and Mechanisms from an Experimental Study,” Education Data Science Conference, Stanford University, 2026
- *Student Presenter*, “Beliefs, Conversations, and Language Development in Early Childhood: Evidence and Mechanisms from an Experimental Study,” Association for Education Finance & Policy (AEFP), Chicago, IL, 2026
- *Student Poster Presentation*, “Exploring the Mechanisms of a Language-Based Parenting Intervention: Evaluation of the LENA Program,” APPAM, Seattle, WA, 2025
- *Mentee*, APPAM Mentorship Program. Mentor: Matthew Stagner, 2025
- *Student Presenter*, “Beliefs, Conversations, and Language Development in Early Childhood: Evidence and Mechanisms from an Experimental Study,” MidSouth Education Policy Workshop, Lexington, KY, 2025
- *Student Presenter*, “Exploring the Mechanisms of a Language-Based Parenting Intervention: An Evaluation of the LENA Start Program,” Rice University’s Third-Year Paper Conference, Houston, TX, 2025

- *Student Presenter*, “Exploring the Mechanisms of a Language-Based Parenting Intervention: An Evaluation of the LENA Start Program,” Texas Applied Microeconomics Students Workshop (TEAMS), *College Station, TX*, 2025
- *Mentee*, CSWEP Mentoring Workshop, *Washington D.C.*, 2024

OTHER EXPERIENCE

Truman State University, Kirksville, MO

- Writing Consultant Spring 2021/2022
- Math Tutor Fall 2019

LEADERSHIP EXPERIENCE

Student Activities Board, Kirksville, MO

2018-2022

President, Special Events Chair, External Affairs Representative

- Directed an event planning organization with a \$475,000 budget during the COVID-19 pandemic;
- Collaborated with agents and University Administration to organize and contract complex events;
- Worked with other campus entities to promote transparency and communication

COCURRICULAR ACTIVITIES

Graduate Economics Association, *Student Representative*, Rice University

2024-Present

Cardinal Key Honor Society, *Parliamentarian*, Truman State University

2020-2022

HONORS / AWARDS

SSRI Dissertation Research Improvement Grant (\$5,000), 2026

Center for Computational Insights on Inequality and Society Research Grant (\$1,899), 2026

Dagobert L. Brito Award for Best Performance by a Recitation Instructor, Spring 2026

AIER's Wesley G. McCain Scholarship in Honor of Murray Rothbard, 2022

Pi Sigma Alpha, 2020-2022

Truman State University President's List, 2018-2022

Harry S. Truman Leadership Scholar, 2018-2022

Gasconade County Math and Science Scholarship, 2018-2022

Missouri Bright Flight Award, 2018-2022

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Programming

Stata, Julia, Python, R (causal_forest), LaTeX

Data Collection and Management

Salesforce, ATLAS.ti, Qualtrics, Box, Square